Gender, Religion and Caste

NCERT Questions

Q1 Mention different aspects of life in which women are discriminated or disadvantaged in India.

Ans women, in our country, are discriminated in the following aspects:

(i) Literacy Rate: The literacy rate among women is only 54% as compared to men with 76% among. Similarly, a few number of girl students go for higher studies because parents prefer to spend their resources for their boys education than spending equally on their daughters.

(ii) Unpaid work: The proportion of women among the highly paid and valued jobs is still very small. Though on an average, Indian women work one hour more then men everyday, most of them are not paid equally and therefore, their work is often not valued.

(iii) Sex ratio: In many parts of India, parents prefer to have sons and find ways to have the girl child aborted before she was born. This has led to a decline in the child sex ratio (the number of girl children per thousand boys) in the country.

(iv) Domestic violence: There are reports of various kinds of harrassment, exploitation and violence against women. Both urban as well as rural areas have become unsafe for women. They are not safe even with their own homes from beating and other forms of domestic violence.

Q2 State different forms of communal politics with one example each.

Ans (a) The expression of communal superiority in every day beliefs: Militant religious groups are good example of this.

(b) The desire to form a majoritarian dominance or a seperate state: separatist leaders and political parties in Jammu & Kashmir and central India are an example of this.

(c) The use of religious symbols and leaders in politics to appeal to the voters: This technique is applied by many politicians to influence votes from the two largest religious communities in the country.

(d) In addition to all this, communal politics can take the form of communal violence and riots, like the riots in Gujarat in 2002.

Q3 State how caste inequalities are still continuing in India.

Ans Caste inequalities have not completely disappeared from India. Even today, most people marry within their own caste or tribe. Despite constitutional prohibition, untouchability has not ended completely. Education is not easily available to the so called 'low castes'. Economics status is closely linked to the caste system. In modern India, like in pre-independence India, the poor are mostly the 'low castes' while the rich are the 'high castes', thereby showing that caste inequalities are still continuing in India.

Q4 State two reasons to say that caste alone cannot determine election results in India.

Ans Caste alone cannot determine election results in India because:

a. No parliamentary constituency has a clear majority of one single caste.

b. No party wins all the votes of a particular caste.

Q5 What is the status of women's representation in India's legislative bodies?

Ans When it comes to representation of women in legislative bodies, India is among the bottom group of nations in the world. Women's representation has always been less than 10% in Lok Sabha and 5% in the state assemblies. On the other hand, the situation is different in the case of local government bodies. As one-third of seats in local-government bodies (panchayats & municipalities) is reserved for women, there are more than 10 lakh elected women representatives in rural and urban local bodies.

Q6 Mention any two constitutional provisions that make India a secular state.

Ans Two constitutional provisions that make India a secular state are:

a. The Constitution provides to all individuals and communities freedom to profess, practice and propagate any religion, or not to follow any.

b. The Constitution prohibits discrimination on grounds of religion.